

Data Retention Schedule

Northwind Analytics Ltd · NW-LEG-007 · Revision 3 · Classification: Internal

1. Purpose

This schedule states how long Northwind Analytics Ltd keeps each category of information and what happens at the end of that period. It supports the Information Security Policy and the Company's obligations under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act.

Retention is a control in both directions. Keeping information longer than necessary increases the harm of any future breach and creates disclosure obligations the Company would otherwise not have. Deleting it too early destroys evidence the Company may need.

2. Governing rules

- The retention clock starts at the trigger event named in the schedule, not at the date the record was created.
- Deletion at the end of a period is automatic and evidenced in the retention log. It is not a task somebody remembers to do.
- Where a legal hold is in force, retention is suspended for the records in scope until the hold is lifted in writing by the Company Secretary.
- Backups follow the retention of the data they contain. A backup is not a permitted route to indefinite retention.
- Where two periods could apply, the longer applies, unless the shorter is a statutory maximum rather than a minimum.

3. Schedule

Client engagement records. Deliverables, correspondence, working papers, and contracts: 7 years from engagement close. Client data processed under an engagement is returned or destroyed within 30 days of close unless the contract says otherwise.

Financial records. Ledgers, invoices, expense claims, tax filings, and supporting evidence: 8 years from the end of the financial year to which they relate.

Employee records. Contracts, payroll, performance, and disciplinary records: 7 years from the end of employment. Medical information: 3 years from the end of employment, held separately with restricted access.

Recruitment records. Unsuccessful applicants: 6 months from the decision. Successful applicants: merged into the employee record.

Security logs. Authentication, authorisation, administrative action, and network flow: 13 months. The period is deliberately just over a year so that an annual pattern remains visible for comparison.

Incident records. Timelines, evidence, and post-incident reviews: 7 years from closure. Evidence that could support a criminal prosecution is retained indefinitely on instruction from the Company Secretary.

Email. 3 years from send or receipt, after which items are deleted from mailboxes and from backup on the backup cycle. Business records that must be kept longer are filed into the appropriate system rather than left in a mailbox.

Instant messaging. 90 days. Messaging is not a system of record and must not be used to hold decisions, approvals, or client commitments.

CCTV. 30 days, extended only where footage is subject to an active investigation.

Marketing contact data. 2 years from the last meaningful interaction, or immediately on withdrawal of consent, whichever is earlier.

Vendor assessments. Duration of the engagement plus 3 years.

4. Deletion standard

Electronic deletion is by cryptographic erasure where the storage supports it, and by overwrite otherwise. Physical media leaving Company control is destroyed by a certified provider and a destruction certificate is retained for 3 years.

Deletion means the record is irrecoverable through ordinary means. Moving a file to an archive folder, removing a database index, or deleting a pointer while retaining the object is not deletion for the purposes of this schedule.

5. Responsibilities

System owners implement retention in the systems they own and confirm annually that automated deletion is running and producing log evidence.

The Data Protection Officer maintains this schedule, reviews it annually, and reports exceptions to the Security Committee. Any system that cannot enforce its stated retention is recorded in the risk register with a remediation date.

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